# Operational Manual

– IEEE Systems, Man & Cybernetics (SMCS)

**Version 2** - 9/17/2025

**Prepared by:**

SMCS Best Practice and Operating Procedure Ad Hoc Committee

Edited by VP Operations and Planning to reflect SMC Constitution, IEEE Constitution and 2023 Techical Manual (reflecting current practice)

Missing from this document:

- BoG Composition and Terms
- BoG Attendance and Termination Rules
- Meeting, Quorum and Proxy Rules
- Financial Disbursement Signatories
- Annual Plan Objective Gathering
- Amendment Procedures
- SMC's formal Field of Interest Definition

**Commented [TG1]:** The Ops Manual inevitably has sections which appear to be good practice and ***expand on*** the words in the Constitution.

If it is to have formal weight, should it be approved by the President / ExCom / BoG? Unfortunately it is unclear what status this Ops Manual actually has.

NOTE: I have made comments when I left in parts which appear to be 'good practice' but the constitution is silent. I have focused on making corrections where the Ops Manual is inconsistent with the constitution and bylaws and where new content does not appear to be documenting current good practice.

**Commented [TG2]:** The filename says V5?

**Commented [TG3]:** This is an excellent concise document.

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## 1. Introduction

This manual provides operational guidance and outlines the best practices to ensure consistency, efficiency, and quality across all IEEE SMCS activities. This operations manual is subordinate to the Constitution and Bylaws. In the case of conflicting wording or lack of clarity, the Constitution and, if necessary, the Bylaws have precedence.

## 2. Scope and Objectives

This manual covers all operational domains within IEEE SMCS, including:

- Governance and Compliance
- Formation and management of Technical Committees
- Editorial processes and publication ethics
- Membership engagement and retention
- Financial planning and accountability
- Conference planning, approval, and quality control

## 3. Organizational Roles and Responsibilities

### 3.1 President

[See Constitution, Article VI, Section 1]

**Commented [TG4]:** Surely President and President-Elect roles should be reproduced here as this is an Ops manual which should be usable without referring to the Constitution. See 3.3 onwards … But 3.10, 3.11, and 3.12 revert to solely referencing the constitution.

### 3.2 President-Elect

[See Constitution, Article VI, Section 3]

### 3.3 Vice President for Organization and Planning

The Vice President for Organization and Planning, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Organization and Planning Committee (OPC), providing leadership in guiding and coordinating the OPC in the development and updating of the Society's strategic and tactical plans, the interpretation of the Constitution and Bylaws, and the preparation of modifications for BoG consideration. He/she shall ensure that the OPC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 2], and represent the OPC's recommendations to the BoG.

### 3.4 Vice President for Systems Science and Engineering

The Vice President for Systems Science and Engineering, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Systems Science and Engineering Committee (SSEC), providing leadership in advancing the Society's systems science and engineering activities. He/she shall ensure that the SSEC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 3a], and represent the SSEC's recommendations to the BoG.

3.5 Vice President for Human Machine Systems

The Vice President for Human–Machine Systems, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Human–Machine Systems Committee (HMSC), providing leadership in advancing the Society's human–machine systems activities. He/she shall ensure that the HMSC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 3b], and represent the HMSC's recommendations to the BoG.

3.6 Vice President for Cybernetics

The Vice President for Cybernetics, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Cybernetics Committee (CC), providing leadership in advancing the Society's cybernetics activities. He/she shall ensure that the CC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 3b], and represent the CC's recommendations to the BoG.

3.7 Vice President for Publications

The Vice President for Publications, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Publications Committee (PC), providing leadership in guiding and coordinating the PC in the formulation, evaluation, and execution of the Society's publications policy and program. He/she shall ensure that the PC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 4], and represent the PC's recommendations to the BoG.

3.8 Vice President for Conferences and Meetings

The Vice President for Conferences and Meetings, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Conferences and Meetings Committee (CMC), providing leadership in guiding and coordinating the CMC in the planning, organization, and oversight of the Society's conferences and meetings. He/she shall ensure that the CMC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 5], and represent the CMC's recommendations to the BoG.

3.9 Vice President for Membership and Student Activities.

The Vice President for Membership and Student Activities, under the direction of the BoG, shall serve as Chair of the Membership and Student Activities Committee (MSAC), providing leadership in guiding and coordinating the MSAC in promoting membership growth, retention, and engagement, as well as supporting student activities and chapters. He/she shall ensure that the MSAC fulfills its responsibilities as provided in the SMCS Bylaws [See Bylaws, Article III, Section 6], and represent the MSAC's recommendations to the BoG.

3.10 Vice President for Finance

[See Bylaws, Article III, Section 7]

3.11 Secretary

[See Constitution, Article VI, Section 4]

3.12 Treasurer

[See Constitution, Article VI, Section 5]

3.13 Associate Vice Presidents, Secretary, and Treasurer

Associates to the Vice Presidents, Secretary, and Treasurer shall support their corresponding officers in carrying out the duties of their offices. They shall perform responsibilities as designated by the corresponding officer and shall report directly to him/her, in alignment with the SMCS Bylaws and policies. Associates may also represent their supervising officer in committee activities when so designated.

3.14 Executive Assistant

The Executive Assistant shall support the President and President-Elect in advancing the Society's mission and strategic objectives. The role includes, but is not limited to, coordinating with officers to ensure effective communication, maintaining records and documentation to strengthen governance, preparing reports as directed, and serving as a primary point of contact for designated Society functions.

3.15 Member-at-Large

Members-at-Large shall serve as elected members of the Board of Governors (BoG) with full voting rights and responsibilities. They shall represent the general membership in BoG deliberations and decisions, share collective responsibility for defining the Society's direction, policies, and development, and may serve on committees or task forces as designated.

## 4. Best Practices and Operational Processes by Area

4.1. Operational Execution of the Constitution and Bylaws

4.1.1. Officer Incapacity and Vacancy

If a member of the Society leadership is unable or unwilling to continue performing their duties, the following steps ~~will~~ should be taken to ensure the position is filled normally within 30 days.

**Commented [TG5]:** This seems to be based on the requirements for VPs and 'assumed' to fit everything

4.1.1.1. President

[See Constitution, Article VI, Section 1]

4.1.1.2. Vice-President

[See Constitution, Article V, Section 1]

Within-term vacancies of a Vice President shall be filled by the President within 30 days of the vacancy's formal announcement to the BoG, from two candidates with ~~biographies~~ names provided by the Nominations Committee.

**Commented [TG6]:** biographies would be a good idea, but it's not in the constitution

4.1.1.3. BoG Member-at-Large

[See Constitution, Article V, Section 2] for Within-term vacancies for BoG Member-at-Large
[See Bylaws, Article IV, Section 4] for a change in officers in the best interest of the Society.

4.1.1.4. Staff (Executive Assistant, Secretary, Treasurer, and Associate officers)

All staff positions shall be appointed in accordance with the processes defined in the Constitution and Bylaws.

4.1.2. Officer Nomination and Election

Individual voting members may propose, by petition, names to be added to the IEEE annual election ballot. All petition signatures shall be submitted electronically through the IEEE annual election website at www.ieee.org/petition ~~[paper petition is outdated]~~

4.1.3. ExCom/BOG Meetings and Voting

4.2. Specialty 'Technical' Committees

**Commented [TG7]:** According to the Constitution we do not have Technical Committees. This is a bylaws change I intend to propose. But for now the best we can do is put 'Technical' in quotes, and use TC as an abbreviation for "Specialty 'Technical' Committees'.

4.2.1. Introduction

Specialty 'Technical' Committees (TCs) are the core units of the IEEE SMCS technical activities, bringing together experts to advance research and applications in specialized domains. Each TC serves as a hub for research, development, and application within its field, and operates under defined leadership and oversight to ensure its effectiveness.

Within the TC structure, governance is carried out through defined leadership bodies and oversight roles.

4.2.1.1. Vice Presidents for Technical Activities (VPs-TA)

The VPs-TA shall provide executive leadership and operational oversight for all TCs. Their primary responsibilities are defined in detail in Sections 3.4-3.6 of this manual.

~~SMCS Technical Activities Board (SMCS-TAB)~~ The corresponding Area Committees (CYBC, HMSC, and SSEC) shall discuss the request of creating a new TC or discontinuing an existing TC. They shall analyze the coverage of TCs within the

SMCS scope, discuss the necessity of creating new TCs and merging existing TCs, and support TC activities.

~~The SMCS TAB shall be established to provide the formal approval, review, and high-level decisions of all TCs regarding their status. The President-Elect shall serve as the appointed Chair of the SMCS TAB, and the three VPs-TA shall serve as members.~~

~~In years when there is no President-Elect, the Chair of the SMCS TAB shall be appointed by the SMCS President. The appointed Chair may be selected from among the current VPs-TA or other qualified members of the Administrative Committee, ensuring continuity of leadership and alignment with the Society's mission.~~

~~4.2.1.3.~~4.2.1.2. TC Chair

The TC Chair shall serve as the primary leader of the TC, responsible for guiding its vision, coordinating activities, and acting as the principal liaison with the Society's leadership

4.2.2. Creation of a Specialty 'Technical' Committee

4.2.1.1. TCs will be formed by VPs for SS&E/HMS/Cyb, including the appointment of chairs of such committees, subject to the provisions of Article III of the Bylaws

~~4.2.2.~~4.2.1.2.

~~4.2.2.1. TC Proposal Requirements~~

~~Creating a new TC begins with a well-structured proposal that outlines its purpose, scope, founding members, and expected contributions. The proposal should include:~~

- ~~Title & Acronym: A clear and concise name that reflects the TC's focus (e.g., "TC on Human-Centered Visual Learning (HCVL)").~~
- ~~Scope & Objectives: A detailed description of the technical area, explaining why it is relevant to the SMC Society and how it differentiates from existing TCs. This section should also highlight potential impacts, such as advancing research, fostering collaborations, addressing emerging industry needs or tackling emerging challenges.~~
- ~~Founding Members: the TC consists of at least 15 IEEE SMC members as the initial members of the TC, which needs to be listed in the proposal with their affiliations. This demonstrates community support and ensures a~~

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**Commented [TG8]:** all of this sounds like good practice, maybe even implemented but it's not in the bylaws. I'm happy to keep these as just 'good practice'. But it's unclear how much of this is documenting current practice or making up new stuff.

~~foundational membership base.~~

- ~~Proposed Leadership: Nominees for one Chair and Vice-Chair(s), along with brief bios or CVs to establish their qualifications. Leadership should be an IEEE SMC member and have a track record in the proposed technical area. There are a maximum of three Vice Chairs representing widely the IEEE regions.~~
- ~~Work Plan: A roadmap for the first two years, detailing planned activities such as conference sessions, workshops, or special journal issues. This shows the TC's potential for active engagement.~~

### ~~4.2.2.8.~~4.2.2.1. TC Proposal Review

A proposal for a new TC shall be submitted by the proposer(s) to the corresponding technical area corresponding area committee. The corresponding area committee conducts an initial review to ensure the submission is complete and relevant and then forwards the proposal to the SMCS-TAB for formal evaluation.

The ~~SMCS-TAB~~corresponding area committee may invite relevant existing TCs to provide evaluation scores and written feedback, particularly with respect to potential overlap or alignment with current activities. Drawing on these inputs, the corresponding area committee ~~SMCS-TAB~~ assesses the proposal's merit, the distinctiveness of its technical scope, its consistency with SMCS goals, and the qualifications of the proposed leadership. Where necessary, the corresponding area committee ~~TAB~~ may request revisions or clarifications. The VP-TA receives the corresponding area committee advice, and decides and communicates consolidated feedback to the proposer(s), who are responsible for revising and resubmitting the proposal. This cycle may be repeated until the corresponding area committee and VP-TA~~SMCS-TAB~~ determines the proposal is ready for recommendation to the BoG.

~~Once the SMCS-TAB completes its review, it shall make a final decision by majority vote of its members. The corresponding area VP-TA shall notify the proposer(s) of the outcome. If approved, the establishment of the new TC is formally declared, and the Board of Governors (BoG) is notified by email.~~If approved by the BoG, ~~Within~~ normally within one week of approval, the VP-TA shall also inform the SMC Website Master~~, the relevant Vice President~~, and the Editor-in-Chief of the IEEE SMC Newsletter, so that announcements can be made. The SMC website shall be updated normally within eight weeks of

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**Commented [TG10]:** This document attempts to replace the BoGs roles by this TAB.

notification, and the new TC shall be introduced in the Newsletter.

~~4.2.2.1. Probationary Period (2 Years)~~

~~A newly approved TC shall begin a two-year probationary phase to demonstrate its viability and impact within the Society. During this period, the TC is expected to establish its activities, membership, and contributions in alignment with the Society's mission and objectives.~~

~~Each probationary TC must organize at least one scholarly or professional event, such as a conference session, workshop, or panel, to demonstrate active engagement with its technical community. In addition, the TC shall submit reports semi-annually, outlining key achievements, challenges, and planned activities for the second year.~~

~~At the conclusion of the two-year period, the TC will undergo a final review by the VPs-TA and the SMCS-TAB to assess its performance, sustainability, and alignment with the Society's goals. Based on this review, a recommendation shall be made regarding the TC's transition from probationary to fully recognized status. The corresponding area VP-TA shall notify the TC chair(s) of the decision.~~

**Commented [TG11]:** I believe this is made up and not documenting current practice. And the TAB does not exist.

~~4.2.7.~~4.2.3. TC Duties

**Commented [TG12]:** This seems good practice, and may be implementing what is currently done.

Each TC is expected to actively contribute to the visibility, scholarly impact, and community engagement of the IEEE SMCS. To this end, TCs are required to organize at least one session annually at a major IEEE SMC event, such as the IEEE SMC Conference, thereby ensuring ongoing participation in the Society's flagship activities.

In addition, TCs are required to contribute to the Society's publications by submitting news items to the SMC eNewsletter and, where appropriate, providing content for other journals, thereby fostering ~~scholarly exchange and knowledge dissemination. TCs are also encouraged to host events such as workshops, webinars, or tutorials to engage the broader professional and research community~~his

Each TC shall also prioritize membership development, with a focus on recruiting new participants and increasing the number of active SMCS members. Growth in membership diversity and engagement is considered a key measure of a TC's vitality and long-term sustainability.

Finally, each TC must submit reports semi-annually to the corresponding VP-TA. These reports shall summarize the committee's activities, member engagement, financials (if applicable), and future

plans, serving as a basis for continued evaluation and accountability. In addition, all TCs are required to participate in the Society's quadrennial review process by submitting the required documentation~~, which will be used by the SMCS TAB to assess long-term performance and viability~~.

### ~~4.2.8.~~4.2.4. TC Management

#### 4.2.4.1. Leadership & Governance

Effective leadership is essential to the success and sustainability of TCs.

Each TC shall be led by a TC Chair, who serves as the primary point of contact and is responsible for steering the committee's direction, coordinating activities, organizing meetings, and reporting to the corresponding VP-TA. The TC Vice Chair(s) provide support to the Chair, assume responsibilities in the Chair's absence, and often lead specific initiatives or subprojects within the TC's scope. An optional Secretary may also be appointed to manage administrative responsibilities, including record-keeping, membership tracking, and support for communications and reporting.

**Commented [TG13]:** I've noticed one new TC which seemed to have 3 co-chairs and 5 vice-chairs (I may be misremembering the numbers) – this may be a spot where ieee can advise on sensible limits to create some personal accountability.

TC Chairs and Vice Chairs shall be appointed for a term of four years. At the conclusion of this term, leadership may be renewed once, subject to review and approval by the corresponding VP-TA, ensuring both continuity and opportunities for new leadership

In the event the Chair is unable to complete a term, a Vice Chair may serve as Acting Chair until a formal appointment is made by the VP-TA~~ in consultation with the SMCS-TAB and the TC leadership team~~.

#### 4.2.4.2. Membership Guidelines

TC membership is open to all scholars with an interest in the committee's technical area, regardless of IEEE membership status. However, it is strongly recommended that each TC actively expand its base of IEEE SMC Society members in good standing, with the expectation that the proportion of SMCS members will grow annually.

TC members are expected to attend at least 50% of TC meetings annually and contribute to at least one TC activity each year (e.g., organizing a session, publishing in IEEE SMC venues).

**Commented [TG14]:** I recall this being discussed. It is unclear to me whether we just consider this good practice etc?

Members who fail to meet participation requirements for two

consecutive years may be removed from the TC roster in order to maintain an engaged and active membership.

#### 4.2.5. TC Evaluation and Recognition

##### 4.2.4.1. Quadrennial Review

Each TC shall undergo a comprehensive review every four years by ~~SMCS-TAB~~the appropriate VP-TA. The review considers activity level, such as consistency in organizing events and producing publications; member engagement, including participation rates and leadership transitions; and overall impact on the Society's visibility and technical advancement. Based on these findings, SMCS-~~TAB-~~BoG may grant continued recognition, recommend specific improvements, or, in rare circumstances, initiate dissolution (see Dissolution).

**Commented [TG15]:** Discussed but not in the constitution. It seems like good practice that we attempt to do currently.

##### 4.2.4.2. TC Recognition

To encourage excellence, standout TCs may be highlighted through featured spotlights in Society publications and considered for nomination to Society-level awards, such as The Most Active TC of the Year. These forms of recognition not only showcase the TC's achievements but also serve to inspire broader engagement and innovation across the community.

#### 4.2.1. Termination of an Inactive TC

The discontinuation of an existing TC could be made if the TC has been in-active for at least one year and there is no credible plan by the TC to revive it. The judgment of a TC being inactive should be largely based on the TC's bi-annual reports and the final decision rests with the corresponding area committee. Alternatively, the discontinuation of an existing TC could also be made by its chair and support of at least two of their TC members by submitting a request to the corresponding area with reason. ~~A TC may be terminated as part of the quadrennial review conducted by SMCS-TAB if it fails to submit required reports for four consecutive years despite follow-up, shows no measurable activity such as events or publications.~~

**Commented [TG16]:** This is from the 2023 Technical Manual so seems to be official current practice. The 4 years seems more like real current practice.

**Commented [TG17]:** should be "final decision rests with the VP-TA on the advice of the corresponding area committee "

## ~~4.4.~~4.3. Publications

#### 4.3.1. Publication Committee

[See Bylaws, Article III, Section 4] Need words here.

#### 4.3.2. Editor-In-Chief Election and Duties

[See Bylaws, Article III, Section 4] Need words here.

#### 4.3.3. Associate Editors Selection and Evaluation

Editorial board members, such as Associate Editors and Senior Editors, as nominated by the corresponding EIC based on seniority, quality, and experience in the required research area. The list of candidates is presented to SMCS Publication EiCs and VP-Pub for comments and endorsement. A specific constraint is that a given person cannot serve as Editor on more than one SMCS-sponsored Transactions at a given time. Upon approval, the appointments will then be made for new Associate Editors. The appointment is for a term of three years, which may begin with an optional one-year probationary period. It is renewable for up to two terms and shall not exceed a total of six years of AE service.

#### 4.3.4. Editorial Assistance

The EICs are supported in their work by members of the Editorial Board, including Editors, Associate and Senior Editors, and Editorial Assistants. For an efficient process of editorial support, SMCS standardizes funding allocation, procedures, and approval criteria. The level of support in a given year shall be determined based on the number of submissions received in the preceding year for each journal. The EIC shall submit the required information and documentation to the VP for Publications, who shall review the data and, in cooperation with the VP for Finance, facilitate the approved support.

#### 4.3.5. Publication Reports and Editorial Meetings

The EICs shall provide regular reports on the state of the journal to the VP for Publications, including submission and publication data, and other information describing the quality of the publication. A semi-annual consolidated report shall be presented to the BoG, coordinated by the Vice President for Publications. In addition, an annual in-person meeting of Associate Editors shall be held in conjunction with the SMCS flagship conference.

### 4.4. Membership

#### 4.4.1. Introduction

The Society is dedicated to advancing the interests of its members and the broader community by fostering the theory, practice, and interdisciplinary development of systems science and engineering, human-machine systems, and cybernetics. Its members form the foundation of the organization, and the Society remains committed to expanding its membership—especially by engaging students and emerging professionals. The Society emphasizes the promotion of its membership diversity

#### 4.4.2. Grades, Right, and Privileges

IEEE members of any grade will become members of the Society upon

application and payment of the Society membership fee. Special categories of members may be designated in accordance with IEEE rules and procedures

4.4.2.1. Member.

A Member of the SMC Society shall hold the grade of Member, or higher grade, in the IEEE. A Member shall have the right to vote in general elections and to run for Society office in accordance with these Bylaws.

4.4.2.2. Affiliate.

An Affiliate shall not be a member of IEEE but shall, by payment of appropriate dues and fees, qualify for Society membership. Society Affiliate membership may be based on membership in other organizations or IEEE societies that have been recognized for affiliation purposes by specific action of the Society's BoG. An Affiliate has the rights and privileges of a Society Member. An Affiliate may serve in an appointive capacity that does not require IEEE membership as a prerequisite.

4.4.3. Application and Admission.

Each application for admission to membership or for transfer to a different grade of membership shall include sufficient evidence of eligibility, in addition to meeting the requirements for admission or upgrade as provided in the IEEE Bylaws.

4.4.4. Members in Good Standing

A member who has paid dues and fees in time, obeyed the IEEE rules and the Society rules, and have no active ethics case is said to be in good standing.

4.4.5. Termination.

Members who become delinquent in the payment of dues and fees shall be treated in accordance with IEEE rules and procedures. In addition, members who breach the IEEE Code of Ethics shall be subject to sanctions as provided in the IEEE Bylaws.

4.4.6. Resignation.

A member in good standing may resign by submitting a written resignation to the Secretary. Subject to the rules and procedures of the IEEE, a resigned member may resume membership upon payment of the current dues, assessments, and fees, as appropriate. Continuity of membership may be obtained by payment of the dues and any assessments or fees pertaining to the lapsed period.

4.4.7. Dues and Fees.

#### 4.4.7.1. Annual dues for Members

Annual dues for Members shall be set each year as part of the budget cycle. Any change in dues will require approval by two-thirds of all voting members of the Board of Governors.

#### 4.4.7.2. Annual dues for Affiliates

Annual dues for Affiliates shall be equal to those of Society Members, plus the Affiliate surcharge as set by the IEEE.

#### 4.4.7.3. Other fees

All other fees or assessments shall be set according to IEEE rules and procedures.

### 4.4.8. Member Discipline

A member of the Society is subject to the rules and procedures of the IEEE and the Society for any action that is determined to constitute a material violation of the Constitution, Bylaws, Policies, Operational Manual or Code of Ethics of the IEEE, or other conduct, which is seriously prejudicial to the IEEE. Such discipline may take the form of expulsion, suspension, or censure for cause by the IEEE.

### 4.4.9. Membership-related Programs

#### 4.4.9.1. Distinguished Lecturer Program

The Distinguished Lecturer Program shall be administered by the Distinguished Lecturer Committee (DPC). The DPC is formed under the oversight of the VP for Membership and Student Activities (MSA) and consists of the DPC Chair (appointed by the VP MSA) and members selected to ensure broad technical and geographic representation. The DPC is responsible for managing the nomination, evaluation, and recommendation process for Distinguished Lecturers.

The Chair of the DPC shall periodically issue a Call for Distinguished Lecturers, outlining the current application requirements and deadlines. Each candidate must submit a biographical sketch, a photograph, the titles and abstracts of at least two lectures, and their availability for lectures to the Chair of the Committee.

The Committee will evaluate and recommend a slate of distinguished lecturers for appointment by the VP MSA. The term of appointment for a distinguished lecturer is normally two years, with a possible two-year extension approved by the DPC.

The names, biographies, pictures, and lecture titles of the Distinguished Lecturers will be sent to the SMC Society Web Editor and the Electronic Newsletter Editor for listing on the SMC Society Website and in the Electronic Newsletter, respectively.

Requests for distinguished lecturers are normally issued by IEEE Organizational Units (e.g., chapters, student branch chapters, local sections, etc.). Requests should be submitted by following the "Requesting a Distinguished Lecturer" information available on the website and sent to the VP for MSA for approval.

#### 4.4.9.2. Travel Grant for Young Professionals and Students

The Society offers travel grants for young professionals and students to encourage engagement and improve retention of young professional members. The grant shall be linked to an SMCS conference and is in the form of travel reimbursement.

##### 4.4.9.2.1. Eligibility

A young professional or student who has a paper (being the author or co-author) accepted by the SMCS conference and has registered and will attend the conference and present the accepted paper.

##### 4.4.9.2.2. Applications

Interested individuals shall submit an application, stating the motivation and the importance of financial support to him or her.

##### 4.4.9.2.3. Selection

Priority will be given to applicants who have been active IEEE SMC members for longer, have limited financial resources, will be traveling from distant regions, and did not receive a travel grant in the previous years.

### 4.4.10. SMCS Chapters

Chapters are membership-related units of the Society established in accordance with IEEE Member and Geographic Activities (MGA) rules.

#### 4.4.10.1. Chapter Formation

An SMCS Chapter is established by petition to the parent geographical unit and the sponsoring technical organizational units (SMCS). This petition to establish a Chapter requires the following information: Name of the Section(s), SMCS as the sponsoring Society, Signatures of at least twelve (12) IEEE voting members, in good standing, who are members of the SMCS and Section(s) involved; a business plan that includes mission and goals, planned meetings and activities for the initial six months. The petition and details about the new Chapter formation can be found https://mga.ieee.org/resources-operations/formations-petitions.

A SMC Student Branch Chapter is established by petition to the parent Student Branch and SMCS. The petition to establish a (Joint) Student Branch Chapter requires at least six (6) signatures, with at least three (3) from the Student Branch and at least three (3) from SMCS members. The petition and details about the new Student Branch and Student Branch Chapter can be found https://mga.ieee.org/resources-operations/formations-petitions,

#### 4.4.10.2. Chapter Reporting

Chapters are required to report to IEEE via vTools for their activities (https://events.vtools.ieee.org/) and current officers (https://officers.vtools.ieee.org/)

Please note that a chapter may be considered inactive when they do not hold at least two meetings a year or fail to report their meetings to the IEEE MGA. Units that have not reported for three years will be dissolved at the next meeting of the IEEE MGA Board.

#### 4.4.10.3. Chapter Recognition

To encourage excellence, standout SMCS Chapters and Student Branch Chapters may be recognized through featured spotlights in both Society and IEEE publications and considered for nomination to Society-level awards, such as IEEE Outstanding SMCS Chapter Award and IEEE Outstanding SMCS Student Branch Chapter Award. These recognitions highlight the Chapter's contributions to member engagement and technical activities, while also motivating other Chapters to strengthen their programs and foster broader participation across the community.

## 4.5. Finance

a) Contract Processing

i. All contracts, including Master Services Agreement, Editorial Services Agreement, Small Vendor Agreement, Grants, Scholarships, Fellowships, and Sponsorships will be required to be submitted via the CMS platform. Some contracts will require significant processing time if IEEE Legal Counsel Review is involved.

ii. The contract proposer will work with the VP Finance and the Secretary for the BOG approval. For Editorial Service Agreements, the VP Publications needs to be involved. Any potential Conflict of Interest (COI) issue needs to be disclosed to the BOG prior to the approval. With the BOG approval, the Treasurer will work with the contract proposer to submit the contract via the CMS platform and work with the IEEE for its approval. The contract goes through the Draft, Review, Negotiate, Approval, Sign, and Managed Stages. After the contract enters the Managed Stage, an additional 7-10 days will be needed for a Purchase Order (PO) to be assigned. The contract proposer shall reference the PO number for invoicing.

b) Budget Forecasting and Management

The Finance Chair works together with the Treasurer and the FC for budget approvals, finance status monitoring, investment, forecasting, adjustment and reporting. A shared drive is recommended to be shared between the FC and the Secretary to store and track documents and prepare for potential IEEE auditing.

c) Travel Reimbursement and Best Practices

i. The Treasurer manages the travel reimbursement approvals for the society, including the travels for ExCom, BOG, Distinguished Lecturers, Student and Young Professionals, Three Technical Areas, Editors, and chapters.

ii. After a travel report is submitted, there will be three levels of approvals, one by the Treasurer and the others by IEEE. Sometimes, the report may be returned for clarifications and corrections at any of these levels. If the reimbursement is not received within a month, contact the Treasurer.

iii. The Treasurer prepares and updates the Society Travel Reimbursement Guideline at the link https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1wB7EfbAfSm-0S5rGM7OipL-nWVNozuWR?usp=sharing. Travelers should follow the guidelines for compliance with IEEE.

iv. Best Practices for society travelers

1. Travelers shall travel economically by booking economy class flights well in advance (preferably 21 days or more prior to your trip).

2. Flight upgrades must be approved in advance of a trip. When submitting the report, attach the upgrade approval email with the flight receipt.

3. Travel insurance for trip cancellation (e.g., airfare) will be reimbursed. The purchase of travel insurance is encouraged to avoid non-refundable costs associated with trip cancellations or changes.

4. Travel reimbursement ~~needs~~ should normally~~to~~ be submitted within sixty days of the travel.

d) Membership Support

i. Chapter support can be issued by following the reimbursement procedures below. (1) Awarded chapters send the detailed cost-breakdown to the grant selection committee for approval. (2) Upon completion of the grant, the awardee uploads receipts to IEEE NextGen for reimbursement following the IEEE Reimbursement rules. (3) The Treasurer works with IEEE for the approval of receipts and reimbursement.

ii. Direct Chapter Fund Transfer is another approach by following the procedures below. (1) Awardee sends the detailed cost-breakdown to the grant selection committee, (2) With the approval, the Treasurer works with IEEE for the direct chapter fund transfer with the attached form. (3) Upon completion of the grant, the awardee sends the expense report for the grant selection committee and the Treasurer for the record.

e) Society Operation Expenses

The Treasurer manages society credit card and operation expenses such as Zoom, Google Space, and equipment.

f) Conference Financial Coordination

i. SMCS may sponsor some events at SMCS financially sponsored conferences. The Treasurer works with the Conference Finance Chair on transferring from different cost centers of the SMCS budget to the conference master account either prior to the event or after the events occur and before the conf. is closed. After the event, the Conference Finance Chair works with the Treasurer on transferring back the remainings.

Event expenses are charged to the conference master account with a specific note indicating its usage (e.g., BoG expenses, Initiative projects, etc.) If a payment is below $5000, the conference account can directly pay. Amounts above $5000 will require a contract in place.

## 4.6. Awards

The Society administers awards and evaluations through two dedicated committees: the Awards Committee, which oversees all Society, publication, and conference awards; and the Fellow Evaluation Committee, which is responsible for evaluations related to IEEE Fellow nominations. All award processes shall be conducted in accordance with IEEE and SMCS Bylaws and policies.

#### 4.6.1. SMCS Society Awards

The Systems, Man, and Cybernetics Society recognizes outstanding members and volunteers and their significant achievements by the presentation of a number of awards. Details of these awards are available on the Society website: https://www.ieeesmc.org/about-smcs/awards/.

The awards process is managed by the SMCS Awards Committee. The Awards Committee shall be formed in accordance with the Bylaws [Article III, Section 8].

A Call for Nominations shall be posted on the SMCS website as the first step in the awards process. Following this, nominations shall also be solicited from multiple designated sources to ensure broad participation. Editors-in-Chief of the Transactions are invited to submit candidates for the Best Associate Editor Award and the Andrew P. Sage Best Transactions Paper Award. Technical Program Track Co-Chairs of the annual IEEE International Conference on Systems, Man, and Cybernetics may submit nominations for the Franklin V. Taylor Memorial Award and the Best Student Paper Award. The Vice Presidents for Systems Science and Engineering, Human–Machine Systems, and Cybernetics are invited to nominate candidates for the Most Active SMC Technical Committee Award, while the Vice President for Membership and Student Activities, together with the Chapter Coordinators, may nominate candidates for the Outstanding SMC Chapter Award.

The Awards Committee shall evaluate the submissions and select the awardees upon receiving nominations and supporting materials. The Committee shall then notify the winners and ensure their availability to attend the upcoming IEEE SMC Society flagship conference, where the awards will be presented. To support this process, the Committee shall maintain a reasonable timeline to allow sufficient time for evaluation, decision, and preparation of presentations at the conference. The Awards Committee Chair shall provide an interim update of the planned timeline at the February ExCom meeting and a final report at the BoG meeting held during the annual flagship conference.

#### 4.6.2. IEEE Fellow Awards

For IEEE Fellow awards, the Society has one formal responsibility: it

must provide a Society evaluation of nominees for elevation to IEEE Fellow. To accomplish this responsibility, SMCS operates through two committees: the Fellow Search Committee, which encourages and supports the preparation of nominations for worthy candidates, and the Fellow Evaluation Committee, which conducts the official Society evaluation of nominees and submits the results to the IEEE Fellow Committee. The final selection of Fellows is made by the IEEE Fellow Committee.

The Fellow Search Committee shall be formed with a Chair and ten members to encourage, identify, and support the nomination of qualified candidates within the SMCS community for IEEE Fellow. The Committee Chair shall be appointed by the President in consultation with the Chair of the Fellow Evaluation Committee. The President, with input from the Fellow Evaluation Committee Chair, shall also appoint the remaining members, with attention to diversity in region, gender, and professional background to reflect the breadth of the Society.

The Fellow Evaluation Committee shall be responsible for conducting the official Society-level evaluation of IEEE Fellow nominees. The Fellow Evaluation Committee shall be formed in accordance with the Bylaws [Article III, Section 9]. It is recommended that the Committee be constituted at least one month prior to the IEEE Fellow nomination deadline. The Committee shall review the nominations submitted to IEEE, prepare evaluations on behalf of the Society, and submit them to the IEEE Fellow Committee by the required deadlines. The results of the evaluations shall be reported to the Board of Governors for record.

#### 4.6.3. Award Presentations

New IEEE Fellows are announced shortly after the last IEEE Board Meeting of the year (typically in the latter part of November). Recipients receive their certificate and a pin in January.

Winners of Society-level awards shall be determined during the Awards Committee meeting held prior to the IEEE SMC Society flagship conference in the nomination year. The awardees shall be announced and their certificates presented at the Awards Ceremony during the annual IEEE SMC conference. Plaques and award checks shall be mailed to the address designated by each winner. All recipients of Society-level awards, including IEEE Fellows, shall also be listed on the Society website.

Recipients of certain awards, including the Norbert Wiener Award and the Lotfi A. Zadeh Pioneer Award, must accept their award in person and are required to present a keynote address at the Society’s flagship conference in October following their selection.

#### 4.6.4. Awards Conflict of Interest Policy

In the establishment of the committees and conduct of all aspects of the award process, it is important that conflicts of interest be avoided.

For the Fellow Search Committee and the Fellow Evaluation Committee, all conflict-of-interest rules specified in IEEE policies shall apply, and SMCS shall ensure full compliance with those requirements.

Members of the Awards Committee are not eligible for awards under evaluation, and while they may encourage nominations, they are not permitted to prepare or submit them. Members of the IEEE SMC Conference Organizing Committee may not serve on subcommittees selecting the finalists or winners of the two conference best paper awards. Voting members of the Board of Governors are ineligible for awards except for the Outstanding Contribution Award and the Meritorious Service Award.

## 4.7. Conferences

IEEE SMC Conferences foster a vibrant platform for disseminating cutting-edge research, showcasing innovative technologies, and promoting industry collaboration in systems science, human–machine systems, and cybernetics.

### 4.7.1. Conference Types

#### 4.7.1.1. Flagship Conferences

IEEE SMCS flagship conferences are premier events organized by the IEEE SMCS. These conferences are fully financially sponsored by the IEEE SMCS, ensuring they receive full support and resources to maintain high standards of quality and impact. The flagship status signifies their importance in advancing the fields of systems science, human–machine systems, and cybernetics by disseminating cutting-edge research and fostering collaboration among researchers, practitioners, and industry leaders worldwide.

Each flagship conference shall follow a rotating schedule, with each year taking place in a different global region:

- One year, it will be held in the Americas (either North or South).
- The next year, it will be held in the Asia/Oceania region.
- The following year, it will be held in the Europe/Africa region.
- After completing this three-year cycle, the rotation

repeats in the same order.

The bidding and proposal processes for hosting the conference occur in a 24–36 month cycle, with details provided in Section 4.7.2.

#### 4.7.1.2. Financially Sponsored/Co-Sponsored Conferences

IEEE SMCS financially sponsored and co-sponsored conferences are events in which IEEE SMCS assumes full or shared financial responsibility, either independently or in partnership with other IEEE organizational units (OUs) or external partners. These conferences benefit from technical expertise, branding, and oversight provided by IEEE SMCS, while also leveraging additional resources and networks provided by the co-sponsoring entities.

Financial sponsorship by SMCS typically includes a negotiated percentage of revenue and expense sharing, as defined in the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) executed for each event. Co-sponsored conferences must comply with IEEE policies, including financial reporting, surplus distribution, and adherence to IEEE conference organization standards.

The bidding and proposal processes for hosting the conference occur in a 12–24 month cycle, with details provided in Section 4.7.2.

#### 4.7.1.3. Technically Co-Sponsored Conferences

IEEE SMCS Technical co-sponsorship indicates direct and substantial involvement by SMCS solely in the organization of the technical program. SMCS has no financial responsibility for the conference. SMCS supports the conference by encouraging members to submit papers and attend the conference and by promoting the conference through the SMCS eNewsletter and website.

IEEE SMCS may wish to negotiate a variety of issues with the sponsoring organization, including registration fees for IEEE members, post-conference sales of proceedings through the IEEE Conference Publications Program, or other arrangements that benefit the conference and foster future collaboration.

For IEEE SMCS Technically Co-Sponsored conferences, it is recommended that the IEEE and SMCS logos be used in all conference publications and announcements. The SMCS

name shall not appear in the conference title.

#### 4.7.1.3.1. Technical Co-sponsorship Timetable

Proposals for technical co-sponsorship shall be submitted to the SMCS VP for Conferences and Meetings no later than one year prior to the start of the conference.

#### 4.7.1.3.2. Technical Co-sponsorship Application

Proposals for technical co-sponsorship, together with the supporting documents listed below, shall be submitted to the SMCS VP for Conferences and Meetings after all conference information has been entered online via the IEEE Conference Application (https://conferences.ieee.org/application/home). The proposal must reference the conference ID (Conference Record Number) provided by the system.

Requests must be accompanied, or immediately followed, by the following:

- The General Chair and Program Chair of conferences should be IEEE SMC Society members
- A Call for Papers (CFP) and a URL to the website containing full conference details (if not already included in the online registration)
- A statement of confirmed interest and intent to support the conference (e.g., organization, paper review) from a representative of one or more IEEE SMCS Technical Committees
- The Conference Approval Profile Form (CAPF) (https://www.ieeesmc.org/wp-content/uploads/2014/03/smc-conference-approval-form.docx).

### 4.7.2. Bidding & Proposal Procedures

This section details the procedures for budding on and preparing proposals for IEEE SMCS flagship and financially sponsored/co-sponsored conferences.

#### 4.7.2.1. Initial Contact & Expression of Interest

##### 4.7.2.1.1. Expression of Interest

- SMCS flagship conferences: the process begins

when a Call for Proposals to Organize the SMC Conference is issued by the SMCS VP for Conferences and Meetings, in accordance with the timetable defined in Section 4.7.1.1. This call should be issued 24-36 months before the event. The prospective General Chair shall then contact the SMCS VP for Conferences and Meetings.

- Other financially sponsored conferences: the process begins with the perspective General Chair contacting the SMCS VP for Conferences and Meetings, which should start 12-24 months before the event

In both cases, the initial communication should briefly describe the intent to organize the conference, including the proposed theme, a preliminary vision for the technical program, and the expertise of the organizing team.

#### 4.7.2.1.2. Preliminary Meeting

If needed, IEEE SMCS VP for Conferences & Meetings will schedule a short meeting to discuss open points, clarify proposal requirements, and ensure alignment with IEEE SMCS strategic goals. The meeting aims to address key aspects such as expected attendance, technical scope, and financial considerations.

### 4.7.2.2. Proposal Preparation

Prospective organizers may prepare the proposal using a template of their choice; however, the proposal shall include the following information:

- Organizing Committee: At a minimum, the Organizing Committee shall include a confirmed General Chair, Program Chair, and Finance Chair. The General Chair and Program Chair must be IEEE SMCS members. For flagship events, the inclusion of experienced co-chairs is strongly encouraged.
- Venue Information: Provide details about the hosting city, the selected venue (hotel, convention center, university campus, etc.), capacity figures, and photos. Include evidence of initial contact and estimated hosting costs.
- Conference Date: Propose the conference date, ensuring compliance with society guidelines and avoiding overlap with other events (coordinate with the VP Conferences and Meetings).
- Finances: Include a preliminary budget using the IEEE

Financial Reporting Tool Workbook (www.ieee.org/documents/financial_reporting_tool.xls). Use the “local currency” sheet and convert to USD or directly fill in USD. Ensure that expense estimates are validated locally and target a surplus of 20% under conservative attendee estimates. The estimates can be as a range of different venues and suppliers.

- Other Relevant Information: Provide any additional details that support the evaluation of the proposal.

#### 4.7.2.3. Proposal Review Process

For flagship conferences, VP for Conference and Meetings shall ensure that at least two bids are received and evaluated through a competitive process. The SMCS Conferences and Meetings Committee shall review all proposals. The two most competitive proposals shall then be recommended to the SMCS BoG for final evaluation and approval.

The General Chairs of the two selected proposals shall be invited to present their proposals at the SMCS flagship conference of that year. A motion shall then be prepared for the IEEE SMCS Board of Governors to announce the evaluation outcome, and the strongest proposal shall be approved.

### 4.7.3. Conference Financial Guidelines

Managing the finances of a conference is a critical aspect of successful event planning. A robust financial strategy ensures that all expenses are covered, revenue targets are met, and the event remains financially viable. Key elements of conference financial management for IEEE SMCS financially sponsored conferences include:

#### 4.7.3.1. Budget Planning

A detailed budget plan should be developed early in the planning process. This includes estimating all potential costs such as venue rental, catering, marketing, travel, speaker fees, and other miscellaneous expenses, aiming for a surplus of 20% over projected expenses. It is crucial to include a contingency fund to cover unexpected expenses. After the conference proposal is approved, the budget must be submitted for IEEE SMCS approval and to IEEE.

#### 4.7.3.2. Budget Management

Conference organizers shall identify and secure multiple revenue streams to fund the event, such as registration fees,

sponsorships, exhibitor fees, and grants. Revenue targets shall be set realistically, taking into account historical data and market analysis.

Expenses shall be carefully monitored and managed to ensure the conference remains within budget. Actual expenditures shall be reviewed regularly against budgeted amounts, with adjustments made as necessary. Cost-saving measures should be implemented where possible, provided they do not compromise the quality of the conference.

#### 4.7.3.3. Banking Options

Once the budget is finalized, it is recommended that conference organizers open a compliant conference bank account with IEEE NextGen Banking (NG). NG is preferred for events conducted in USD or CAD, functioning similarly to a local checking account with capabilities for revenue collection, check issuance, and online transfers. Funds may also earn monthly interest.

To open an NG account, organizers should contact the IEEE SMCS conference business analyst.

#### 4.7.3.4. Financial Reporting

Transparent and accurate financial reporting is essential. Conferences are required to close all dedicated bank accounts, distribute any surplus, repay outstanding loans, submit final financial reports to the IEEE Conference Services Department, and complete the required audit within twelve months of the conference conclusion (completion within six months is strongly recommended).